

MID-RANGE PHONES

With cell phones becoming part of everyday life, let us take a closer look now at some widely used mid-range phones, and identify the model with the right balance of style, features, usability and performance. After all, who doesn't long for that perfect phone.

We will discuss cell phones that comprise the mid-range category. Priced at Rs 5,000 and above, these phones offer more than just mere basic features. They are essentially visually appealing, and not meant for just calling and messaging. People obsessed with colour screens, and managing personal information on their cell phones opt for these handsets. However, camera phones and Java-enabled sets don't fall into this category.

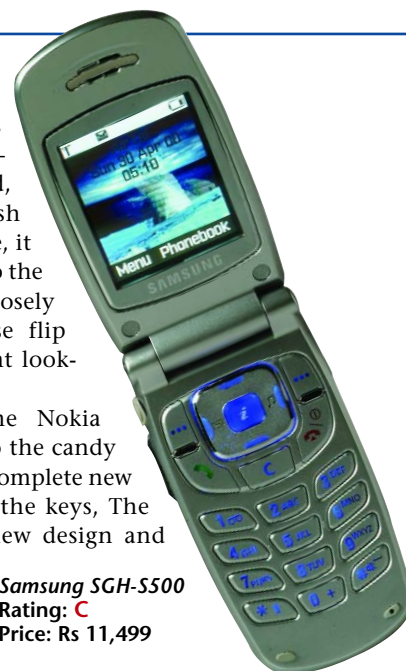
Mid-range phones come with a variety of interesting options—ranging from simple monochrome screens to the exquisite and lively 270K coloured ones. Despite the craze over rich 270K colour screens, most of today's mid-range cell phones are still in the modest 4K colour domain, with features that are, after all, decent enough for the average user.

Users of mid-range phones experience much better connectivity while travelling. There are obviously several other

G7030 and Pantech's G300, are real beauties. The Pantech G300 is exceptionally striking—with its splendid, contoured body, stylish looks and compact size, it will definitely appeal to the fairer sex. Following closely on the heels of these flip phones was the elegant looking Philips 630.

Nothing beats the Nokia 2300 when it comes to the candy bar look. Exhibiting a complete new design by playing on the keys, The 2300, with a brand new design and spectacular layout of keys, can make you forget that it is, after all, a mere

Samsung SGH-S500
Rating: **C**
Price: Rs 11,499



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features that make these phones handy while on the go.

The table clearly shows that mid-range phones throw open lot of options when it comes to the number of brands available. Top brands, such as Nokia, Samsung, LG, Sony-Ericsson and Motorola, all thrive on the category of mid-range sets. Even lesser known names in the market, such as BenQ and Pantech, offer at least one mid-range model. Already, Philips, Sagem and Panasonic are fighting for a foothold in the mid-range domain with some really good models.

The Koreans stand taller than the others (no, we're not being sarcastic or punning here) when it comes to style and class. Korean manufacturers have invariably come up with the best-looking compact flip phones. Samsung's LG G7030
Rating: **C-**
Price: Rs 13,000

SGH-X430 and SGH-S500, LG's

phone. Bird's S288 is easily the slimmest cell phone we have come across, and it actually looks like a colourful candy bar.

The impressive aluminium finish of the Phillips 9@9++ sets it apart from other contemporary models. Phones from Sagem, though, are modelled to resemble the popular Nokia sets, without any distinct design or style of their own. BenQ, Alcatel and Siemens models are not too impressive in terms of looks. Some are too dull looking, while others are way too flashy to be impressive—many of them resemble other phones from the past. Sony-Ericsson's T230 at least sports a unique look, though its rectangular body with chiselled edges can hardly be called eye-candy.

Panasonic, the all-time specialist in Bonsai models, has done it yet again with the smart EB-G51. But for the jutting antenna, the G51 really fits perfectly into your palm. Motorola

Nokia2300
Rating: **B+**
Price: Rs 6,919

